The Blueprint

By Percy Pham

(WIP - Part of a bigger project)

INT. RESTAURANT - NIGHT - DREAM

An after-work crowd unwinds in dim, lively comfort that is filled with laughter. It's just a normal Friday night with my friends after a very long week of work. It feels like everyone in this restaurant is at the point in their life where they just slip into the safety of a routine, with only the occasional night out to hide the burnout from their life.

SAM

How is he right now?

Leo just pushed his French fries dish toward Sam.

LEO (CONT'D)

He said he's fine. He remarried after a few years. New son, new wife. He's also dealing with cancer somehow, and I think he's pretending he's okay, especially for his two kids.

Everyone paused for a moment. The room felt darker, lit only by candles scattered across the tables. Their flames flickered, casting golden reflections that danced along the walls and shimmered in quiet eyes.

SAM

How about your dad?

LEO

He is doing well.

SAM

I mean the story.

LEO
Oh… uhh… My dad decided not to go study abroad and stayed with my mom.

VIOLET
Wait why? Like, people had phones back then, you know.

MARK
Yeah, I also wondered that. What life could have been if you knew you were from the U.S.? Would we even have met each other?

LEO
I don't know. But I did ask my dad last Sunday, though.

VIOLET
Seriously, what did he say?

LEO
Well, he simply doesn't really value being filthy rich and successful that much. Plus, my mom was carrying my sister back then, so if he left, she would have to take care of her alone for four years. He said his family needed him more than his career at that time.

MARK
Fair point!

Leo took a sip of his now cool drink and said.

LEO
Pretty sure if he left for the U.S., there is no way I would come to exist since I am four years older than my sister.

SAM
So we would not meet each other.

Leo smiled

LEO
Yeah, and I have been thinking about this lately. Why do you guys want to be rich?

SAM
To buy cool stuff that normal people can't afford. Like whatever I want.

MARK
Right, and that is what is important? Have you even listened to Leo's dad? I want to be rich for my family.

He slipped an arm around her, pulling her close, giving her a soft shake. Anna was visibly brushing.

LEO
I like that idea…

VIOLET
Experience. I think having an option to just try. Like, we are still in our 20s. There are more things to do.

LEO
I'm with you, Mark. I've never wanted to be rich just for the sake of it. What I want is to take care of the people I love, to give them a life that feels full and secure. If I had someone, I'd want them to have the best life I could give them. The fulfilling one.

SAM sarcastically said.
If you had someone

LEO
There's something beautiful about it, about being able to provide, you know.

After taking a bite from his pasta dish, Mark looked at Leo and raised his beer slightly, almost like a toast to no one, and drank.

MARK
Leo, you are the cutest guy that I know.

LEO annoyed
I swear, why?

Violet had been surprised by the reaction. Even though she had many male friends and understood the typical banter, teasing, and rage baiting, the exchange had seemed strange to her, as it had to everyone else.

VIOLET
What?

LEO
Why do I only hear those compliments from guys and not girls? Like, am I just that unlucky in relationships?

SAM
I don't know. Sounds like you are very popular with guys.

MARK
Yeah, that is a very great observation actually. Why don't you try the other gender? Expand your search.

LEO
Bro, I am not gay.

Mark and Sam erupted into uncontrollable laughter, as if they had been bottling up every last bit of lightness all week just for that moment. The girls seemed to simply enjoy it as well, but not to the same extent as the two guys.

EXT. RESTAURANT - NIGHT - DREAM
They finished their meals, and the laughter and conversation slowly faded as they settled the bill. The friends stepped out into the cool night air. Sam, Anna, and Mark drifted off. Leo and Violet stood a little apart, closer to the curb, where Leo checked his phone for their ride.

LEO
Looks like my Uber is still two minutes out.

Violet shivered slightly, pulling her cardigan tighter.

VIOLET
Mine is like ten.

LEO chuckled, putting his phone away.
Hey. I just wanted to say... thanks.

VIOLET
For what? For being a great friend? You're welcome.

LEO
No, ha ha. I mean for this. For introducing me to them. To Sam, Mark, and Anna, a while ago. It's been... nice, honestly.

VIOLET
We needed you. You're fun in your weird way.

LEO

I appreciate it. It means a lot.

The lights of an approaching car sweep across the street. Leo checked the license plate. The Uber driver brought his window down.

UBER DRIVER
Is this Leo?

LEO
Yeah, that's me.

Leo turned back to Violet. Noticing she was still shivering, he quickly unzips his black washed hoodie and hands it to her.

LEO
Here. Put this on. It's colder than I thought. And I am heading home now, so just take it.

Violet hesitated for a second, looking at the hoodie.

LEO (CONT'D)
Take it. But remember to give it back. Seriously, this is my favorite hoodie.

Violet smiled, pulling the oversized hoodie on.

VIOLET
Thanks. Get home safe. See you Sunday.

Leo waves a final goodbye and climbs into the back seat. As the car pulls away, she watches the taillights disappear into the city traffic, standing alone under the streetlights, wrapped in the warmth of the hoodie.

Maybe a life is actually that simple. We overcomplicate the search for a perfect, successful existence, but perhaps all we truly need are these brief breaks from the routine. There is no need for a perfect Hollywood successful lifestyle. Perhaps the blueprint for a good life was never about chasing success, but just about collecting these small, unscripted moments that make everything else worth enduring.